

A Short History of Forgetting

In 1885 a German psychologist named Hermann Ebbinghaus did something a sensible person would do. He memorized lists of nonsense syllables -- BOK, YAT -- and then measured, over days and weeks, how much of each he had lost. He was both the scientist and the only subject, which is either admirable dedication or a very quiet decade.

What he found has held up remarkably well. Forgetting is fastest at the start: much of a new list is gone within the first day, and the loss slows to a gentle slide. Plotted on a graph, the drop looks like a slope that levels off, and it has been called the forgetting curve ever since.

The more useful finding is what flattens the curve. Each time the material was reviewed, it was forgotten more slowly afterwards. Reviews spread over many days did far more than the same amount of review crammed into one sitting.

Modern studies call this the spacing effect, and it is one of the most reliable results in all of psychology.

For students the lesson is plain, if inconvenient: an hour a day for days beats four hours the night before. For instructors it is plainer still. A reading that a student cannot open, search, enlarge or list is a reading they cannot review -- and a reading nobody can review is reading everybody forgets.

Discussion questions

1. Why might nonsense syllables have been a clever choice, and a limit?
2. Describe a time spacing your practice helped you learn something.
3. What would make this page easier for you to review next week?